Letter and application writing

Subject: English | Level: Class 10 | Curriculum: Federal Board
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1. Topic Overview and Learning Objectives

Letter and application writing are fundamental skills in the Class 10 English curriculum, serving as a primary means of formal communication. In the Federal Board examination, these tasks carry significant weight, often accounting for a substantial portion of the writing section. Mastering these formats is not just about passing the exam; it is about developing the ability to convey information, requests, or grievances clearly and professionally in real-world scenarios.

The importance of these formats in board exams cannot be overstated. Examiners look for strict adherence to the prescribed format, including the correct placement of the sender address, date, salutation, and complimentary close. A well-structured letter or application demonstrates your command of English grammar, tone, and organizational logic. Even if your content is excellent, failing to follow the standard layout can lead to unnecessary mark deductions, which is why precision is your best friend here.

The fundamental intuition behind formal writing is clarity, conciseness, and courtesy. Whether you are writing a letter to a newspaper editor or an application to your principal for a fee concession, the goal is to be polite yet firm and direct. By understanding the purpose of each section—from the subject line in an application to the body of a letter—you can ensure that your message is received and understood exactly as you intended, leaving a positive impression on the examiner.

2. Core Concepts and Detailed Revision Notes

2.1 The Anatomy of a Formal Application

A formal application is a structured request directed to an official, such as a principal or a government officer. In the Federal Board syllabus, the application must follow a specific sequence. It begins with the designation of the recipient, followed by the name of the institution and the city. The subject line is crucial as it provides a concise summary of the purpose of your application. The salutation should be formal, such as Sir or Madam. The body of the application must be brief, stating the reason for the request clearly without unnecessary fluff. Finally, the subscription, such as Yours Obediently, followed by your name and class, completes the document. Maintaining a professional tone throughout is essential to ensure your request is taken seriously by the authority figure you are addressing. You must ensure that the left margin is perfectly aligned for all elements of the application.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Always start with the designation of the recipient on the left margin.
2. The subject line should be short and highlight the core purpose.
3. Use formal salutations like Sir or Madam consistently.
4. Keep the body of the application to three short paragraphs: introduction, reason, and request.
5. End with a formal subscription like Yours Obediently.

2.2 Mastering the Personal Letter Format

Personal letters are written to friends, family, or acquaintances. Unlike formal applications, these allow for a more relaxed and conversational tone, yet they still require a standardized layout to be considered correct in an exam setting. The letter begins with the sender address and date on the top right corner. The salutation, such as My dear friend, is followed by a comma. The body of the letter is where you express your thoughts, share news, or ask about the well-being of the recipient. It is important to maintain a warm and affectionate tone throughout. The subscription, such as Yours sincerely or With love, is placed on the right, followed by your name. Even though the language is informal, the structure must remain neat and organized to satisfy the requirements of the board examiners. Consistency in alignment is key to achieving full marks.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Sender address and date are placed on the top right corner.
2. The salutation should reflect your relationship with the recipient.
3. The body should be written in a friendly and engaging tone.
4. Paragraphs should be clearly indented or separated by spaces.
5. The subscription must align with the sender address on the right.

2.3 Writing Letters to Editors

A letter to the editor is a unique hybrid of formal and persuasive writing. Its purpose is to highlight a social issue or express an opinion on a public matter. The format follows the formal letter style: sender address on the right, followed by the recipient designation and address on the left. The subject line is mandatory to inform the editor about the topic of your letter. The language must be objective, respectful, and persuasive. You should clearly state the problem, provide evidence or examples, and suggest a possible solution or call to action. Avoid overly emotional language; instead, focus on facts and logical arguments. This type of letter tests your ability to articulate public concerns effectively, making it a favorite topic for board examiners to assess your critical thinking skills and your command of formal English vocabulary.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Include the address of the newspaper office as the recipient.
2. The subject line is essential for the editor to identify the topic.
3. Maintain a neutral, objective, and professional tone throughout.
4. Focus on the social impact of the issue being discussed.
5. Conclude with a clear suggestion or a request for publication.

2.4 Tone and Punctuation Essentials

The tone and punctuation of your correspondence define your professionalism. In formal applications, the tone must be respectful and humble, avoiding slang or overly casual expressions. In personal letters, you can be warm, but avoid being sloppy with your grammar. Punctuation is a major area where students lose marks. Ensure that commas are used correctly after the salutation and the subscription. Avoid using unnecessary exclamation marks or informal abbreviations like u for you or r for are. Every sentence should be grammatically sound, and the flow between paragraphs should be logical. Remember that the examiner is looking for clarity and correctness; therefore, proofreading your work for spelling errors and punctuation mistakes is a vital step before finalizing your answer in the exam hall. A clean, error-free presentation significantly boosts your credibility.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Use formal language for applications and friendly language for letters.
2. Never use abbreviations or slang in formal correspondence.
3. Place commas correctly after salutations and subscriptions.
4. Ensure consistent indentation throughout the document.
5. Proofread for spelling and grammatical errors before finishing.

3. Key Definitions, Formulas, and Rules

1. **Sender Address:** The address of the person writing the letter, placed at the top right for personal letters and top left for formal letters.
2. **Salutation:** The greeting used at the start of a letter or application, such as Dear Sir or My dear friend.
3. **Subject Line:** A brief, one-line summary of the purpose of a formal application or letter to an editor.
4. **Subscription:** The closing phrase of a letter or application, such as Yours Obediently or Yours Sincerely.
5. **Formal Tone:** A style of writing that is objective, respectful, and free from slang or contractions.
6. **Body Paragraphs:** The main content of the letter, usually consisting of an introduction, the main message, and a conclusion.
7. **Recipient Designation:** The title and office of the person receiving the application, placed on the left side.
8. **Date Format:** The standard date format used in exams is Month Date, Year, e.g., May 20, 2024.

4. Step-by-Step Worked Examples

Example 1: Application for Sick Leave

Problem: Write an application to your Principal for three days of sick leave.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Start with The Principal, School Name, City on the left.

Step 2: Write the Subject: Application for Sick Leave.

Step 3: Use the salutation: Sir.

Step 4: State the reason for absence and the duration clearly.

Step 5: End with Yours Obediently, Name, and Class.

Final Answer: The Principal, ABC High School, Islamabad. Subject: Application for Sick Leave. Sir, I am writing to request leave for three days as I am suffering from fever. I will be unable to attend school from May 20 to May 22. Kindly grant me leave. Yours Obediently, X.Y.Z, Class 10.

Example 2: Letter to a Friend

Problem: Write a letter to your friend thanking them for a birthday gift.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Place your address and date on the top right.

Step 2: Use a friendly salutation like My dear friend.

Step 3: Express gratitude for the gift in the first paragraph.

Step 4: Mention how you will use the gift.

Step 5: Close with a warm subscription like Yours sincerely on the right.

Final Answer: Examination Hall, City A.B.C, May 20, 2024. My dear friend, Thank you so much for the beautiful watch you sent for my birthday. It is exactly what I wanted. I will cherish it forever. Yours sincerely, X.Y.Z.

Example 3: Letter to the Editor

Problem: Write a letter to the editor about the problem of water shortage in your area.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Sender address on the right, recipient address on the left.

Step 2: Include a clear subject line.

Step 3: State the problem clearly in the first paragraph.

Step 4: Provide details and request action in the second.

Step 5: Sign off formally with Yours truly.

Final Answer: Examination Hall, City A.B.C, May 20, 2024. The Editor, Daily News, Islamabad. Subject: Water Shortage in our Area. Sir, I want to highlight the water shortage in our locality. We face severe issues daily. I request the authorities to look into this. Yours truly, X.Y.Z.

Example 4: Application for Fee Concession

Problem: Write an application to the Principal for a fee concession.

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Standard formal application header on the left.

Step 2: Subject: Application for Fee Concession.

Step 3: Explain the financial hardship clearly.

Step 4: Request the principal to consider the application.

Step 5: Formal closing with Yours Obediently.

Final Answer: The Principal, ABC School, Lahore. Subject: Application for Fee Concession. Sir, My father is a low-income employee and cannot afford my school fees. I request you to grant me a fee concession. Yours Obediently, X.Y.Z, Class 10.

5. Common Exam Mistakes to Avoid

1. Mixing up the placement of addresses: Always check if it is a formal or personal letter.
2. Using abbreviations: Avoid writing u, r, or thx in any formal document.
3. Incorrect punctuation in salutations: Always use a comma after the salutation in a letter.
4. Vague subject lines: Ensure the subject line is specific and descriptive.
5. Ignoring the word limit: Keep your applications concise and to the point.
6. Poor formatting: Ensure the left and right margins are respected according to the standard format.

6. Practice Questions and Model Answers

Question 1

Write an application to your Principal for a character certificate.

Answer 1: The Principal, ABC High School, City. Subject: Application for Character Certificate. Sir, I have passed my SSC examination from your school this year. I need a character certificate for college admission. Kindly issue it to me. Yours Obediently, X.Y.Z.

Question 2

Write a letter to your father requesting money for books.

Answer 2: Examination Hall, City A.B.C, May 20, 2024. My dear Father, I hope you are well. I need some money to buy my new textbooks for the upcoming term. Please send me two thousand rupees. Yours affectionately, X.Y.Z.

Question 3

Write a letter to the editor about the increase in street crime.

Answer 3: Examination Hall, City A.B.C, May 20, 2024. The Editor, The Daily Times, Islamabad. Subject: Increase in Street Crime. Sir, I am writing to express my concern regarding the rising street crime in our city. The authorities must take immediate action. Yours truly, X.Y.Z.

Question 4

Write an application for a change of section.

Answer 4: The Principal, ABC High School, City. Subject: Application for Change of Section. Sir, I am a student of Class 10-A. I wish to change my section to 10-B as my friends are there. Kindly allow me to do so. Yours Obediently, X.Y.Z.

Question 5

Write a letter to your friend inviting them to your brother's wedding.

Answer 5: Examination Hall, City A.B.C, May 20, 2024. My dear friend, I am happy to invite you to my brother's wedding on June 5. Your presence will make the occasion special. Yours sincerely, X.Y.Z.